

The Ghost of AYODHYA

Politics in 21st century India does not need to manipulate the past for secular atonement

By S. Prasannarajan

On a wintry December day in 1992, our faith in the civility of a secular India was demolished by the madness of a mob fed on mythology. Almost 17 years later in the House of Parliament, our faith in the fairness of the Indian state was demolished by a voluminous screed on the evil project of Hindu nationalists. Ayodhya—a word that takes us back not only to the ruins of tolerance but also to the rage that brought the Indian Right to power—has returned. It is spectral politics all over again. For, the report of the Liberhan Ayodhya Commission of Inquiry is very generous in its platitudinous hotchpotch and naming of all those familiar Parivar baddies. It is short on specifics (the only surprise being the inclusion of the “pseudo-moderate” Atal Bihari Vajpayee and it may be because Justice M.S. Liberhan wants to impress Baddie No. 1 and the author of “pseudo-secularism” with his own pun power.) Liberhan’s recommendations, aptly complemented by the Action Taken Report by the government, have the sanctimonious gravity of a Whither-India editorial. In our hoary history of crimes and evasions (Delhi 1984, Godhra and Ahmedabad 2002), this is just another costly piece of national abdication. We are still a land without justice.

What has our own variation of the Truth Commission finally achieved? It has made truth a disputed—or even dubious—item in the flea market of politics once again. By colour coding the culprits in deep saffron, the Commission has given the aggrieved political Hindu his Ram back. Liberhan’s editorial flourish makes it all the more easy for some BJP worthies, diminished and discredited otherwise, to regain their victimhood in the age of secular one-upmanship. Take this, if you need a sample: “The BJP was and remains an appendage of the RSS which had the purpose only of providing an acceptable veneer to the less popular decisions and a façade for the brash members of the Sangh Parivar.” Now that the Truth Commissioner has taken the role of a political pundit (note that operative “and

remains”), the persecuted nationalist and the fringe fanatic are being united. Also, the Commission portrays Vajpayee, unarguably the human face of the Indian Right, as some sort of a kar sevak and exonerates P.V. Narasimha Rao, the then prime minister. (Had Rao known in advance that something of this nature was coming, he could have perhaps avoided the tedium of writing his version of truth in a memoir that was, at the request of the author, published posthumously.) If the official practice of secularism in this country is invariably the appeasement of minority ghettos, the Congress has every reason to be inspired by Liberhan’s laborious report.

Still, as a 21st century democracy, India should be worried about its politics returning to displaced gods. The BJP may be tempted to revisit the last remains of the so-called vandalised civilisation for ideological sustenance. Dreading the future, the party may once again take refuge in the past. That will be a total negation of the zeitgeist—and an acceptance of its own redundancy. Indian politics is in the post-Ayodhya phase, and the BJP can’t afford to refute this, no matter how desperate it is. And it is desperation that drives nationalists in dire times to the make-believe of a great yesterday. To be a modern, responsible right-wing party, the BJP doesn’t have to shop in the backyards of mythology for slogans. It just needs to open its mind and read the present. As the Congress, after two general election victories, steps into the danger

zone of triumphalism, a smart opposition should not be facing a drought of issues. The BJP is not smart enough to be the effective counterpoint. The Congress, on its part, is borrowing from the demonology of Liberhan’s report to market its secularism. It too needs Ayodhya.

Does India need Ayodhya today? There is no national virtue in forgetting. The politics that feasts on the profanity of Ayodhya 1992 shames India further. Every living nation has a historical memory but only the least confident of them will manipulate it politically. ■

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